

The Long Road to RECOVERY

The surprise result is proof that performance is not always the only barometer



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

**ASHOK GEHLOT FLANKED
BY HIS SUPPORTERS**

| By Rohit Parihar |

Vasundhara Raje thought she had found an unconventional but a sure-shot formula for success—curb incumbency. So, in a desperate attempt to win a second consecutive term as Rajasthan chief minister, she and her core team decided to change half of the 122 incumbent BJP MLAs to counter the bane of anti-incumbency, and it had the blessings of the party patriarch Lal Krishna Advani, but unfortunately the strategy boomeranged. The loss has taught one lesson to BJP: there is no such formula for winning an election.

Five years ago, Raje was plucked out of Delhi's socialite circles and sent to Rajasthan to take on Ashok Gehlot, a village magician's son and the incumbent Congress chief minister. The BJP's spectacular victory in 2003 worked in her favour and catapulted her to the

league of the BJP's list of rising young stars. This time though the electoral prospects were reversed: the Congress won 96 out of the total 200 seats and the BJP got just 78 compared to 120 last time.

Gehlot, Raje's predecessor and possible successor, the architect of the Congress victory in the state, shed his trademark image of a genial, soft-spoken politician and aggressively attacked her. He addressed 140 rallies against the 70 that she did, used every available podium to describe the Raje government as the most corrupt in Rajasthan's history. A cursory look at the BJP winners shows that most of them were ministers or candidates perceived close to Raje and targeted by the Congress for their alleged tainted image. Many of them, however, had delivered and hence won which points to the fact that cor-